User Stories

A user story is a short, simple description of a required feature told from the perspective of the person who desires the new capability – usually a user or customer of the system.

A user story reflects a user's point of view. It should describe something the user wants to do with the system. It must tell a story and be easy to understand.

User stories are an outline requirement, which eventually require further discussion to fully establish the business need before building the feature. The stories are written from the perspective of the user (or, better still, by an actual, or potential representative user).

3Cs Framework - Card

The underlying principles for user story development are summarised in the 3Cs framework:

Card: Each user story is documented using a card format; this limits the amount of information about the user story.

The card is a written description of the story used for recording and planning. card can also be a piece of software, such as Jira.

It represents a user story, physically, and it has three components: role, goal and benefit (or rationale). This means a user story must state the user role, what the user wants to achieve (a goal) and why it is important to the user (benefit or rationale).

3Cs Framework - Card

Every story must fulfil a requirement with a specific goal or benefit. It is always advisable to break any story into smaller stories if it has more than one goal.

The user story is written on a card, sticky note, or electronic equivalent and then added to the backlog.

As a ... (who is the user role or actor?)

I want ... (capability or feature is needed)

so that ... (why it is the beneficial to the user role)

3Cs Framework - Card

Examples for an airline:

As a passenger

I want to book multiple flights at the same time

so that I can save time making bookings and claiming expenses

As a passenger handling agent

I want to be able to search on "empty seats"

so that I can reallocate if a customer if their seat isn't suitable

Users with different perspectives may request the same functionality, so there is usually a degree of merge and deduplication work to do. The details of the perspective should be retained. For example, both a passenger and a handling agent may wish to view a booking, for different reasons and will need different access rights, but essentially both if their stories will relate to the same feature.

3Cs Framework - Conversation

Each user story is the basis, or ‘placeholder’, for a conversation where the user story is explored in further depth.

So, a key question here is **how do we achieve the goal using the system?** To answer this question, consider the following:

- What information is needed for the user to make the decision?
- What information needs to be communicated?
- How will the information be conveyed?

3Cs Framework - Confirmation

Each user story can only be deemed to have been fulfilled if it is evaluated against defined acceptance criteria and it is confirmed that these criteria have been met.

So, a key question here is **how do we verify if the story is done and complete, and the goal is achieved?** To answer this question, go about writing action statements from the user's point of view. For example:

Acceptance criteria are statements attached to a user story. They help the team define what success looks like from a user perspective. They are typically a list of statements which have a clear result which prove that the feature is testable.

Acceptance Criteria

Acceptance criteria can be expressed in the Given, When, Then (GWT) format.

Here is an example:

As a customer,

I want to select a payment type from my profile,

So that I don't need to re-enter my payment information.

Acceptance Criteria

The acceptance criteria for this user story is might be:

- **Given** that I have items to check out,
- **When** I proceed to payment,
- **Then** My stored payment methods are displayed and can be selected.

The given is a pre-condition that must be true before the action is taken and states the selected scenario. When is the action taken and then is the expected outcome.

If the story is also to cover deleting or adding a payment card or method, this can be written as separate acceptance criterion, worthy of a separate test in Functional Testing and User Acceptance testing (UAT).

Acceptance Criteria

Acceptance criteria aren’t meant to be an all-inclusive list of every little detail - they are meant to give the team enough information to remember, discuss and test the story.

It is not uncommon for Business Analysts to revisit and possibly reword user stories when adding acceptance criteria, because the act of adding the acceptance criteria forces clear logical thought processes which may consider new things. The BA would of course collaborate with business experts before amending the story.

User stories and acceptance criteria will be explored further during the business requirements and user centric design module.

Acceptance Criteria

Users with different perspectives may request the same functionality, so there is usually a degree of merge and de-duplication work to do and the details of the perspective should be retained. For example; both a hotel guest and a receptionist may wish to view a booking, for different reasons and will need different access rights, but essentially both if their stories will relate to the same feature.

Writing User Stories from different Perspectives

Music Festival Example

Music Festival Example

Who might be the users of a music festival booking system? There are for example customers, the events booking admin officer, the manager, the accountant and other external agencies such as third-party booking sites.

The point of capturing requirements as user stories is to gather requirements from individual users. So, you, as business analyst, will work with the product owner to speak to people who use this new system and ask them, ‘how would you use the system?’

Music Festival Example

Typical customer user stories may be….

As a customer, **I want** to see a images of festival, **So that** I know to expect when I get there.

As a customer, **I want** to see my festival bookings, **So that** I have quick access to full details of my bookings.

As a customer, **I want** to be able to book multiple bookings in one order, **So that** I will know that we have secured tickets for all of my friends and I.

Typical event marketing staff stories may be:

As a marketer, **I want** to get a report of all bookings, **So that** I can decide when to start, stop or change a campaign.

As a marketer, **I want** to see all planned events in the next year, **So that** I can plan my marketing campaigns.

As a marketer, **I want** to see a report of all sales per marketing channel, **So that** I can evaluate the success of each channel.

Music Festival Example

Event manager's point of view:

As an event manager, **I want** to get a report of ticket holders with different accessibility needs, **So that** I can ensure that all aspects of accessibility are being addressed.

As an event manager, **I want** to get a report identifying income and expenditure by month, **So that** I can identify how to reduce expenditure.

As an event manager, **I want** to get a detailed report of completed bookings per event, **So that** I can plan staffing and facilities needed for each event.

Possible stories from the accountant

As an accountant, **I want** to get a report of ticket sales during a period, **So that** I can gauge total revenue.

As an accountant, **I want** to get a report that identifies peaks and troughs in sales, **So that** I can smooth cashflow.

As an accountant, **I want** to get a report on all operating expenses, **So that** I can consider efficiencies in cost management.

Music Festival Example

Stories from the perspective of a third party booking provider

As a booking agent, **I want** to allow customers to complete an online booking in two steps, **So that** customers have a smooth experience.

As a booking agent, **I want** to send customers updates related to their events, **So that** they contact us with fewer queries.

As a booking agent, **I want** to get a report identifying total booking fees per event, **So that** I can monitor revenue.

User Stories

User stories help to clarify what the user requirements are from the individual stakeholders that will use that system. Note that different user types may need representation, especially for external customer user groups. It is likely that users with families and those with different accessibility needs will have different needs. The users represented will depend on the situation, maybe corporate and individual guests will have different needs for example, or different age or social demographics.

Technical Stories

While user stories are worked on by product owners and business analysts, technical stories are typically worked on by system architects and developers. These stories may describe features that are necessary for the operation of the system but are of no or little interest to end users and business stakeholders. For example:

- upgrading a database
- refactoring code
- automating tests
- cleaning out unused code

Technical Stories

Often, a product backlog includes a combination of types of requirements, such as new, value-adding features, infrastructure upgrades, elimination of technical debt or fixing other known issues.

Businesses typically get excited about new features and products, sometimes to the detriment of other kinds of work. There is the danger that important technical stories get pushed down the priority order further than they should be. Note however that it is not always possible to deliver user stories in an IT project without a technical story.

What is not a User Story?

It is important to make the distinction on what is also not a user story. For example:

- Work tasks that a developer would need to do are not user stories
- Broader architecture-related requirements are not user stories
- Project planning activities are not user stories.